

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Nouns 1

Part 1: Case



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Case

Case is a way of marking a noun phrase for its role in a sentence. It's already familiar to you as an English speaker, although you might not know it. English pronouns have different forms depending on where they are in a sentence: "I" for a subject, "me" for an object, and "my" for a possessor. That's case! In many languages, case marking extends much further, showing up not only on nouns and pronouns, but also on adjectives, articles, and numerals. Case is assigned to a noun phrase as a whole and can show up on anything inside it. Here I'll introduce a handful of common case designations. Each of these is just a "prototype" or idealized version of what a case means or does. In real languages, there's always overlap and variable use. Having a case whose use completely matches the textbook definition is a sure sign of a conlang, so use these descriptions as a fluid guide rather than a rigid mold.

Core cases are assigned based on a noun's relationship with the verb. Remember from the explainer on morphosyntactic alignment, how you can group verb arguments? If you haven't read that, now's a good time. If it's been a minute, here's a recap: Intransitive verbs have a single argument, called S for subject. Transitive verbs have two arguments, a more active one called A for agent and less active one called P for patient. Languages often want some way of differentiating A and P, and choice of noun case is a common way to do that.

A case that marks the S and A arguments is called the **nominative** case. Its counterpart, marking the P case is the **accusative** case. Generally, the case that includes marking S in its job is the least marked form. It might have no affix or and speakers will likely think of it as the default form, which they use in isolation or when talking about the word itself. Here's an example of nominative and accusative articles from German (Germanic, Indo-European).

1. Der Hund läuft.
der hund läuft
the.M.NOM dog runs
"The dog runs."
2. Der Mann sieht den Hund
der mann sieht den hund
the.M.NOM man sees the.M.ACC dog
"The man sees the dog."

On the other hand, you can group S/P and leave A by itself. A case that marks both S and P is **absolutive** and one that marks just A is **ergative**. Since it includes S, absolutive is generally the less marked case. Take a look at these examples from Dyirbal (Pama-Nyungan), where the bare noun is absolutive but the ergative is marked with an affix.

3. yabu banaga-nyu
 mother.ABS return-NFUT
 "Mother returned."

4. yabu ŋuma -ŋgu bura-n
 mother.ABS father-ERG see -NFUT
 "Father saw mother."

Some verbs take two objects, and it's common to have another case than nominative/accusative or ergative/absolutive to mark the additional object. For example, some languages have a distinct case to mark recipients or benefactors, which is called the **dative** case. Here's an example of the dative case from Turkish (Turkic).

5. Kadına çay verdim.
 kadın-a çay ver -di -m
 woman-DAT tea give-PST-1S
 "I gave the woman some tea."

All of these cases so far mark a noun's relationship to the verb, but that's not all case can do. Not all nouns are immediately tied to the verb. Think about the sentence "John's mother sees our dog." The words "John's" and "our" don't have any direct relationship to the verb. Neither John nor us are seeing or getting seen, so it doesn't make sense for the verb to assign case to those phrases. What they are doing is *modifying other nouns*. "John's" specifies whose mother is doing the seeing and "ours" is showing whose dog is getting seen. A case that shows this kind of relationship is called the **possessive** or **genitive case**. The genitive is most prototypically used to show possession or ownership, but it can also be used for association, part-whole relationships, origin, participation in an action, and a whole slew of other things. As a conlang creator, it's up to you to determine the usage of your language's cases, and *then* label them. Don't let the prototypical labels control you!

In addition to showing up as arguments of verbs or modifiers of other nouns, nouns can show up as objects of adpositions (a more general term referring to both prepositions and postpositions which are like prepositions but after the noun instead of before, like "ago" in "four years ago"). As you might expect, adpositions can also assign case to nouns. Some languages have a specific case just for adpositions, but it's fairly common for them to assign one of the other existing cases. Some languages assign the same case with all adpositions, for example Finnish (Finnic, Uralic) postpositions assign the genitive case to their objects. In other languages, different adpositions assign different cases. Sometimes this is lexical: each adposition assigns a specific case that you just have to learn word-by-word. Other times, it's based on the semantics of the adposition. It's common to associate movement towards something with dative or accusative, movement away from something with genitive or ablative, and so on. There are also cases where a preposition can assign *multiple* cases depending on context. In German, the preposition *in* assigns the dative case when referring to a static position in a location, but the accusative case when referring to motion into a location.

Rather than being used to mark a relationship with another part of the sentence, some cases are used adverbially to convey additional information about the location, time, or means of an event. More or less anything a preposition can do, a case can also do. There's an indefinitely large number of locative and

adverbial cases, and as usual, different languages divide them differently. I think it's less helpful to list them all out than to think about some of the distinctions that natural languages can make. First off, there's a common three-way distinction between motion towards a location, static position in a location, and motion away from a location. Motion towards is prototypically called **allative**, location in is **locative** and motion away is **ablative**. Some languages also make a distinction between motion generally towards something and motion all the way up to something. In addition to type of motion, languages can distinguish types of position. Rather than just a general "location," languages might distinguish being inside of an enclosure, being on a surface, being in front of or behind an object, or being near or far from an object. You can also imagine a case that combines any type of motion with any location. Movement away from nearby something? In Lezgian they call that the **adelative** case. Static location touching the surface of something? That's Tlingit's **pertingent** case. For any type of salient distinction, you can find an adverbial case for it.

It's cool to learn about the diversity of cases, but don't think that you have to use twenty-four different locative cases to get your point across! Meaning in natural languages is never clear-cut and it's more likely than not that a single case will do more than just its prototypical task. Even with relatively small case systems, you can still end up with a lot of obliques that only get role marking from case, not from adpositions. Take the Turkish ablative case, for example. The prototypical meaning of the ablative is motion away from something. The Turkish ablative covers that, as well as related notions like something's source.

6. Amerika'dan Türkiye'ye gittim.
amerika-dan türkiye-ye git-ti -m
america-ABL turkey -ALL go- PST-1s
"I went from America to Turkey."

It also covers a wider range of uses, including a material used to make something, a cause of an event, some adverbial expressions, even as an object of certain emotional verbs.

7. Kumdan bir kale yaptık.
kum- dan bir kale yap- tı -k
sand-ABL one castle make-PST-1p
"We made a castle out of sand."

8. Açlıktan olacak.
açlık -tan ol -acak
hunger-ABL die-FUT
"He will die of hunger."

9. Senden gerçekten nefret ediyorum.
sen-den gerçek-ten nefret ed-iyor-um
2s -ABL truth -ABL hate do-PROG-1s
"I really hate you."

These all have different meanings, but they're covered by a single case, without the help of any adpositions. You can just as easily have twenty-seven highly specific cases as you can five semantically vague cases.